

Salo

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saturnian

CASSINI-HUYGENS MISSION

xanadu

LIQUID HYDROCARBON

microbial life

ONTARIO LACUS

space age

Titan is the only natural satellite known to have a dense atmosphere, and the only object other than Earth for which clear evidence of stable bodies of surface liquid has been found. Titan is the sixth ellipsoidal moon from Saturn.

Frequently described as a planet-like moon, Titan has a diameter roughly fifty percent larger than Earth's moon and is eighty percent more massive.

It is the second-largest moon in the Solar System, after Jupiter's moon Ganymede, and it is larger by volume than the smallest planet, Mercury, although only half as massive. Titan was the first known moon of Saturn, discovered in by the Dutch astronomer Christiaan Huygens.

The moon itself is primarily composed of water ice and rocky material. Much as with Venus prior to the Space Age, the dense, opaque atmosphere prevented understanding of Titan's surface until the Cassini-Huygens mission.

Liquid hydrocarbon lakes exist in the satellite's polar regions, which are the only large, stable bodies of surface liquid known to exist anywhere other than Earth.